

Turning the tide against tobacco in India

Tobacco use in rural India **is** not **merely** a personal choice — it is a social norm **ingrained** in everyday life. From **chewing** gutka and khaini to smoking bidis and adopting modern nicotine products, the habit begins early and **often** continues **unchallenged**. Cultural acceptance, lack of awareness, and **deep-rooted** traditions have made tobacco use a normalised behaviour in villages across the country. While tobacco-related **illnesses afflict** all income groups, it is India's rural poor who **suffer** most — facing higher **exposure**, **minimal** healthcare access, and **scarce** **cessation** support. Urban-focused awareness campaigns often **overlook** where the crisis hits hardest: rural India, home to over 65 per cent of the population. For many families, tobacco is more than a health **hazard** — it's an economic burden.

When a family member falls ill due to tobacco use, the costs of treatment, lost wages, and **premature** death can **plunge** households into a cycle of **poverty**. Even then, many remain unaware of the true dangers, as the tobacco industry **thrives** on **misinformation** that spreads **unchecked** in rural communities. Yet, rural India is not powerless — it is **resilient**. When **empowered**, it becomes a **driving force** for change. The solution **lies** not in top-down **enforcement** but in local leadership, education, and community **collaboration**. **One** of the most powerful starting points for change **is** within the school system. A truly tobacco-free school goes beyond **signage** — it **cultivates** a culture. When School Management Committees (SMCs), teachers, students, and parents work together, they create a united voice against tobacco use. SMCs often hold significant authority and trust in rural areas. When they **collaborate** with teachers to lead classroom discussions, organise awareness rallies, and involve parents in **outreach**, they **instil** long-term behavioural shifts in children.

The message is clear: tobacco is not a **rite** of passage, but a barrier to health and opportunity. These committees also play a key role outside school gates, ensuring vendors don't sell tobacco near educational institutions. Their **vigilance** turns policy into practice and sets community standards that protect future generations. ASHAs, Anganwadi workers, and Sakhis form a **vast** network of trusted health messengers in rural India.

As insiders, not outsiders, their influence runs deep. These women speak the local language — both literally and culturally — and use their **proximity** to **counsel** families, especially pregnant and **lactating** mothers, about the dangers of tobacco **exposure**. **Tobacco use** during pregnancy **increases** the risk of **miscarriage**, low birth weight, and long-term developmental challenges. Through regular home visits and patient, **empathetic** conversations, these health workers **combat myths**, change behaviours, and break intergenerational cycles of addiction. They also play a vital role in promoting awareness of non-communicable diseases (NCDs), which **account for** 63 per cent of deaths in India. Tobacco is a leading cause of these diseases, yet rural awareness remains low. Health workers are at the frontline of change — conducting **screenings**, making referrals, and shifting **fatalistic** attitudes to hopeful, **preventative** mindsets. Rural India's **social fabric** is tightly **woven** — and **therein lies** its strength. Self-

Help Groups, Panchayats, Mahila Federations, teachers, and youth leaders can collectively transform attitudes. Street plays, door-to-door sessions, and village-wide awareness **drives help demystify** the harms of tobacco and **dismantle** its cultural **stronghold**.

When villages declare themselves “tobacco-free” under COTPA, it sends a powerful message: change is possible through community **conviction**, not just government enforcement. To defeat tobacco in rural India is to **restore** health, **dignity**, and opportunity. The path forward lies in supporting schools, **empowering** frontline workers, and **mobilising** communities to challenge deeply **embedded** norms. NGOs, CSR initiatives, and local governments play crucial roles — but it is the people who hold the real power. Because the future of a tobacco-free India will not be built in policy documents or urban boardrooms. It will rise from the classrooms, clinics, and **courtyards** of rural India — one conversation, one community, one **courageous** step at a time. [Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

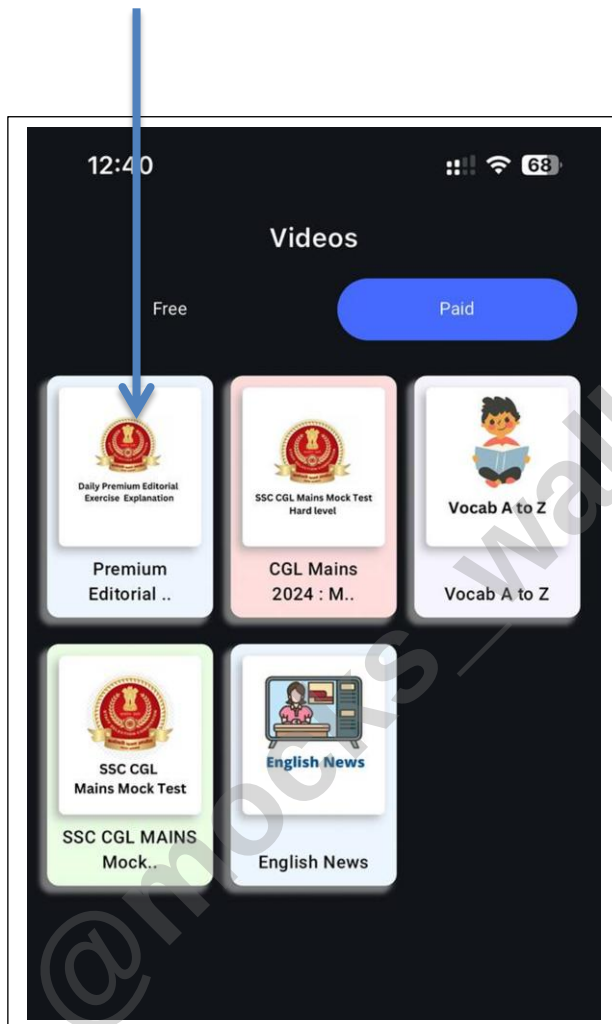
Vocabulary

1. **Turn the tide** (phrase) – reverse, transform, shift, alter, overturn – स्थिति बदलना
2. **Merely** (adverb) – only, just, simply, purely, solely – केवल
3. **Ingrained** (adjective) – embedded, rooted, fixed, deep-seated, entrenched – गहराई से स्थापित
4. **Chew** (verb) – munch, bite, gnaw, crunch, chomp – चबाना
5. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, habitually, commonly, repeatedly – अक्सर
6. **Unchallenged** (adjective) – unopposed, undisputed, unquestioned, unchecked, unrefuted – बिना विरोध के
7. **Deep-rooted** (adjective) – entrenched, ingrained, established, firm, abiding – जड़ें जमाई हुई
8. **Illness** (noun) – disease, sickness, ailment, disorder, condition – बीमारी
9. **Afflict** (verb) – trouble, torment, burden, plague, beset – पीड़ा देना
10. **Suffer** (verb) – endure, undergo, experience, bear, face – भुगतना
11. **Exposure** (noun) – contact, vulnerability, revelation, disclosure, uncovering – संपर्क / अनावरण
12. **Minimal** (adjective) – least, negligible, bare, minor, marginal – न्यूनतम
13. **Scarce** (adjective) – limited, rare, meagre, insufficient, scant – दुर्लभ
14. **Cessation** (noun) – end, stop, termination, halt, discontinuation – समाप्ति
15. **Overlook** (verb) – ignore, neglect, miss, disregard, omit – नज़रअंदाज़ करना
16. **Hazard** (noun) – danger, risk, threat, peril, menace – खतरा
17. **Premature** (adjective) – early, untimely, hasty, rushed, unseasonable – असमय
18. **Plunge** (verb) – fall, drop, sink, dive, tumble – गिरना / डूबना
19. **Poverty** (noun) – destitution, hardship, deprivation, indigence, scarcity – गरीबी
20. **Thrive** (verb) – flourish, prosper, grow, succeed, bloom – फलना-फूलना
21. **Misinformation** (noun) – falsehood, lies, untruth, disinformation, fabrication – गलत जानकारी
22. **Unchecked** (adjective) – uncontrolled, unrestrained, rampant, unregulated, unbridled – बिना रोकटोक
23. **Resilient** (adjective) – strong, tough, adaptable, durable, hardy मज़बूत

24. **Empowered** (adjective) – enabled, authorized, capable, entitled, strengthened – सशक्त
25. **Driving force** (noun) – catalyst, motivator, influence, leader, propeller – प्रेरक शक्ति
26. **Lie** (verb) – rest, exist, reside, be situated, dwell – स्थित होना / होना
27. **Enforcement** (noun) – implementation, execution, imposition, compulsion, application – प्रवर्तन
28. **Collaboration** (noun) – cooperation, partnership, teamwork, alliance, synergy – सहयोग
29. **Signage** (noun) – signboard, display, marker, placard, notice – संकेत-पट
30. **Cultivate** (verb) – develop, foster, nurture, build, grow – विकसित करना
31. **Collaborate** (verb) – cooperate, work together, unite, partner, coordinate – सहयोग करना
32. **Outreach** (noun) – extension, approach, engagement, communication, contact – पहुंच / जागरूकता कार्यक्रम
33. **Instil** (verb) – implant, infuse, inculcate, introduce, nurture – डालना / सिखाना
34. **Rite** (noun) – ritual, ceremony, custom, tradition, observance – संस्कार / परंपरा
35. **Vigilance** (noun) – alertness, caution, watchfulness, attentiveness, surveillance – सतर्कता
36. **Vast** (adjective) – huge, immense, expansive, extensive, enormous – विशाल
37. **Proximity** (noun) – nearness, closeness, adjacency, vicinity, immediacy – निकटता
38. **Counsel** (verb) – advise, guide, instruct, direct, recommend – सलाह देना
39. **Lactating** (adjective) – nursing, breastfeeding, milk-producing, nourishing, maternal – स्तनपान कराती हुई
40. **Exposure** (noun) – contact, influence, experience, involvement, revelation – संपर्क
41. **Miscarriage** (noun) – abortion, stillbirth, loss of pregnancy, failed pregnancy, prenatal loss – गर्भपात
42. **Empathetic** (adjective) – compassionate, understanding, caring, sensitive, considerate – सहानुभूति रखने वाला
43. **Combat** (verb) – fight, tackle, resist, oppose, confront – लड़ना / मुकाबला करना
44. **Myth** (noun) – misconception, fallacy, legend, belief, fable – मिथक / झूठी धारणा
45. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – represent, explain, make up, contribute, comprise – ज़िम्मेदार होना

46. **Screening** (noun) – testing, examination, check-up, evaluation, scan – जांच
47. **Fatalistic** (adjective) – resigned, hopeless, despairing, accepting, submissive – भाग्यवाद में विश्वास रखने वाला
48. **Preventative** (adjective) – precautionary, protective, preemptive, defensive, deterrent – रोकथाम संबंधी
49. **Weave the social fabric** (phrase) – build community, strengthen bonds, unite society, integrate, foster solidarity – सामाजिक ताना-बाना बुनना
50. **Therein lies** (phrase) – that is where exists, within it lies, in that rests, the key is in, thus resides – वहीं पर निहित है
51. **Drive** (noun) – Movement, campaign, अभियान
52. **Demystify** (verb) – clarify, simplify, explain, decode, unravel – स्पष्ट करना
53. **Dismantle** (verb) – break down, demolish, undo, destroy, take apart – खत्म करना
54. **Stronghold** (noun) – bastion, fortress, center, hub, domain – गढ़ / मजबूत केंद्र
55. **Conviction** (noun) – belief, certainty, faith, assurance, confidence – दृढ़ विश्वास
56. **Restore** (verb) – recover, reinstate, revive, bring back, rebuild – पुनर्स्थापित करना
57. **Dignity** (noun) – self-respect, honour, nobility, worth, esteem – गरिमा
58. **Empower** (verb) – enable, authorize, strengthen, equip, liberate – सशक्त बनाना
59. **Mobilise** (verb) – activate, gather, organise, deploy, rally – जुटाना / सक्रिय करना
60. **Embedded** (adjective) – entrenched, fixed, ingrained, implanted, rooted – समाहित
61. **Courtyard** (noun) – yard, patio, quadrangle, cloister, open space – आँगन
62. **Courageous** (adjective) – brave, bold, fearless, valiant, heroic – साहसी

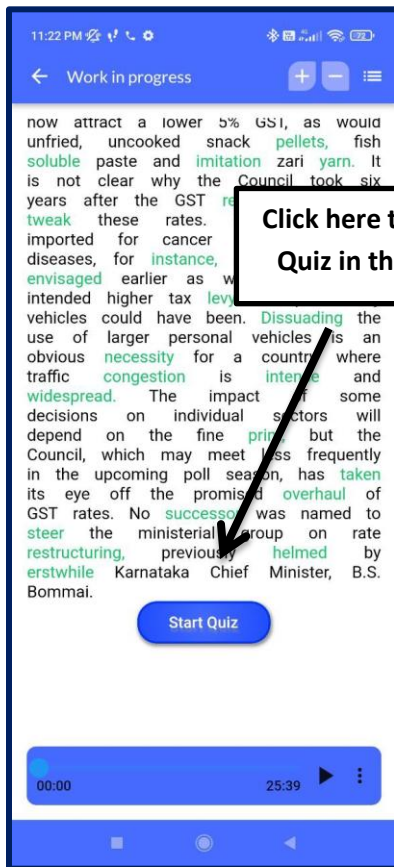
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



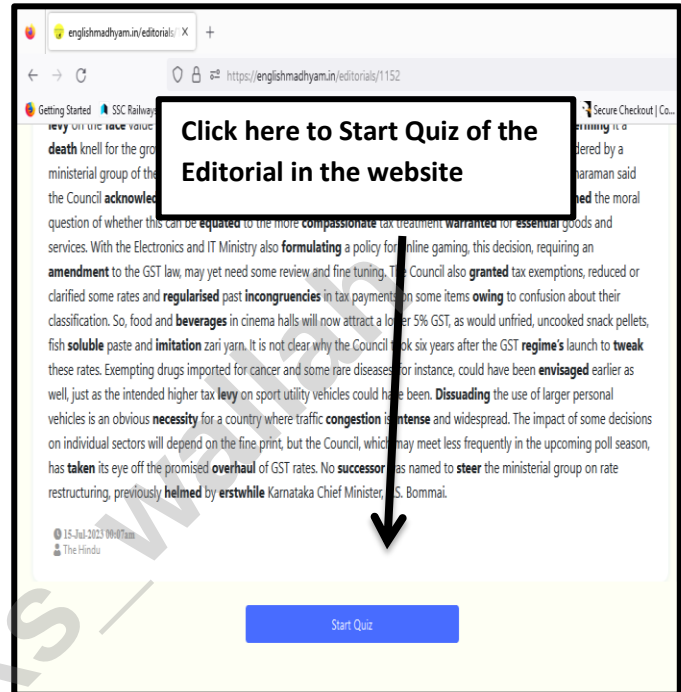
Summary of the Editorial

1. Tobacco use in rural India is normalized, driven by cultural acceptance, tradition, and lack of awareness.
2. Forms of tobacco like gutka, khaini, and bidis are widely used, often starting at a young age and continuing unchecked.
3. Rural poor face the worst impact, with high exposure, low access to healthcare, and minimal support for quitting.
4. Urban-centric awareness campaigns neglect rural areas, even though over 65% of India's population lives there.
5. Tobacco causes major economic hardship, pushing families into poverty due to medical expenses and loss of income.
6. Misinformation by the tobacco industry spreads easily in villages, keeping people unaware of its full dangers.
7. Empowerment through local leadership and education is key, not top-down enforcement.
8. Schools and School Management Committees (SMCs) can drive change, by promoting awareness and shaping young minds.
9. True tobacco-free schools involve students, teachers, and parents, creating a community culture against tobacco.
10. SMCs also ensure vendors don't sell tobacco near schools, turning laws into effective action.
11. Frontline female health workers (ASHAs, Anganwadi workers, Sakhis) play a crucial role in counselling families.
12. They build trust through language and cultural familiarity, influencing behaviours, especially among pregnant women.
13. Tobacco during pregnancy increases risks, such as miscarriage, low birth weight, and child development issues.
14. Health workers raise awareness of tobacco-linked non-communicable diseases (NCDs), which cause 63% of deaths in India.
15. Community mobilisation — through SHGs, panchayats, and awareness drives — is essential, as lasting change comes from rural India itself, not from policies alone.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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